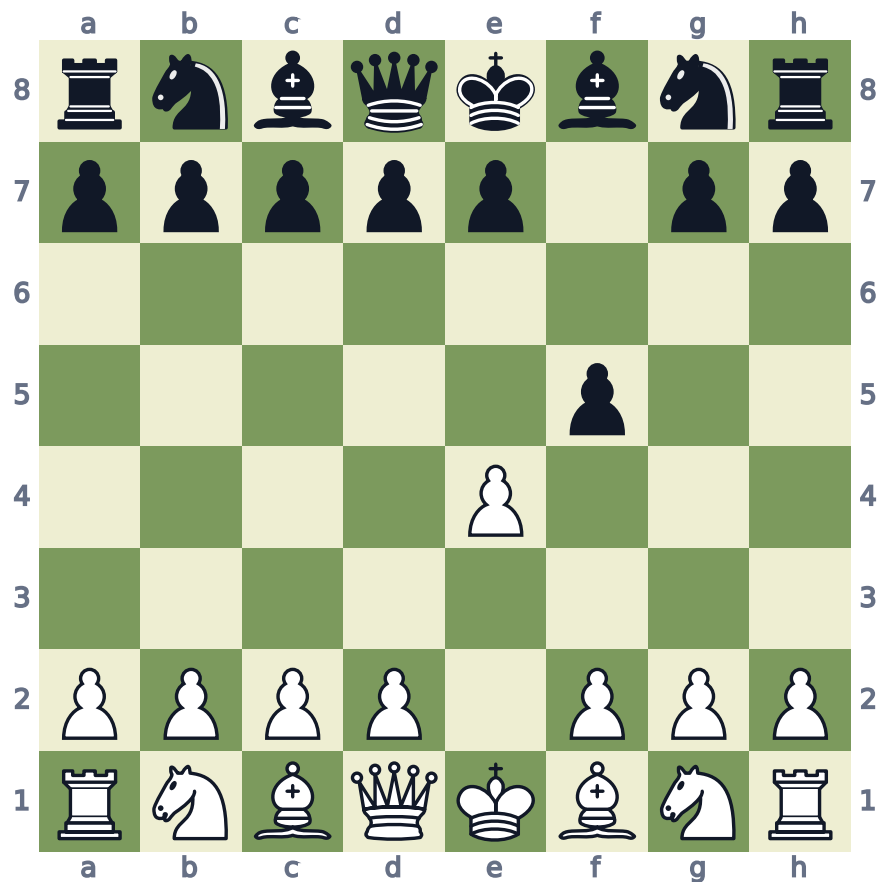


1.e4 Tactics, Traps, and Defensive Resources

Open-file geometry, f7 pressure, central blows, poisoned pawns, pinned defenders, and safe def



Train recurring tactics from 1.e4 openings while learning to distinguish a sound combination from a hope-chess trap.

36 learning units | diagrams | recall tests | engine-checked analysis

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Train recurring tactics from 1.e4 openings while learning to distinguish a sound combination from a hope-chess trap.

THE TRAINING LOOP

- First identify Black's defense from pawn placement and move order.
- At every diagram, name the center, the urgent threat, and two candidate moves.
- Hide the recall answer until you have spoken the move and its purpose.
- Replay each line from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 36 units inside a connected White repertoire. It covers the main structural and move-order decisions you need for practical play; the PGN companion makes later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

Open positions make uncastled kings tactical targets.

PRINCIPLE 2

f7 is vulnerable because only the king defends it initially.

PRINCIPLE 3

A central pawn break can attack pieces by opening lines.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

Pinned defenders may not be able to recapture.

PRINCIPLE 5

Queen attacks matter when they develop another piece with tempo.

PRINCIPLE 6

Calculate the opponent's most forcing reply before committing.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

TACTICAL PROTOCOL

How to solve opening tactics without guessing

STEP 1

Update the board after the last move: new attacks, lost defenses, and opened lines.

STEP 2

List every legal check, major capture, and direct threat for both sides.

STEP 3

Identify loose pieces, pinned defenders, overloaded pieces, and exposed kings.

STEP 4

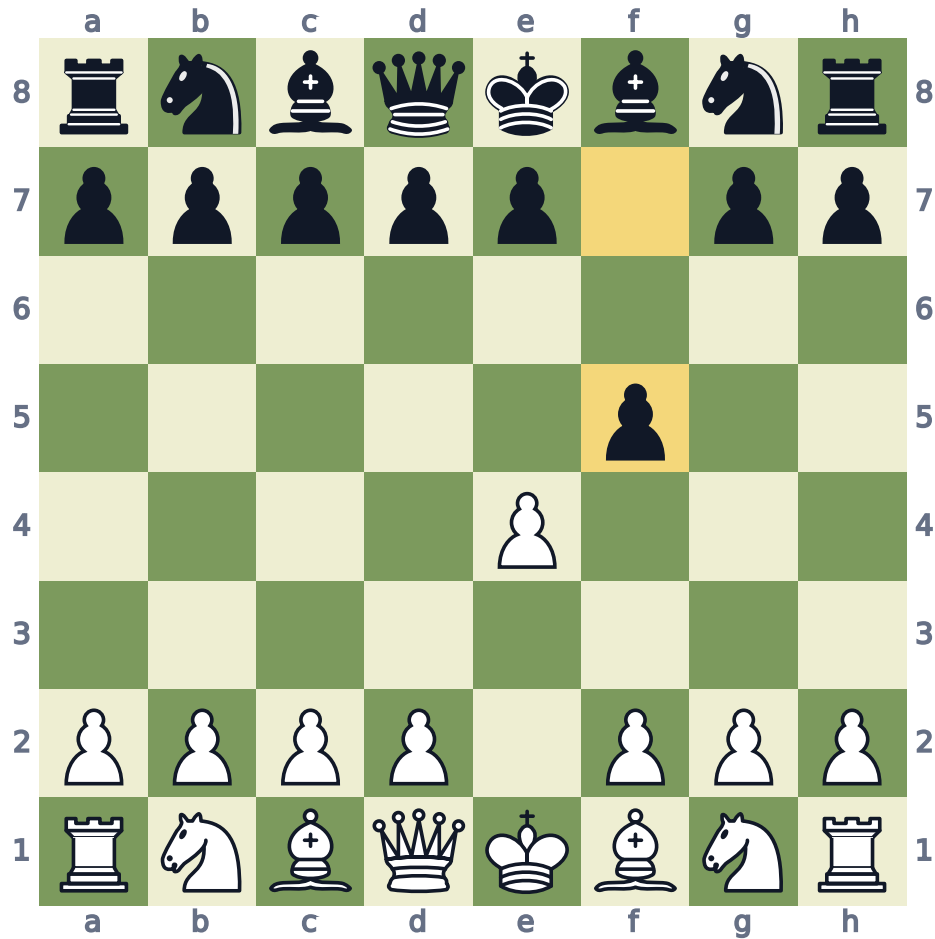
Calculate the opponent's strongest forcing reply before choosing.

STEP 5

At the endpoint, count material and evaluate king safety, development, and center.

TACTICAL TEST 01 OF 36

Fred Defense



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

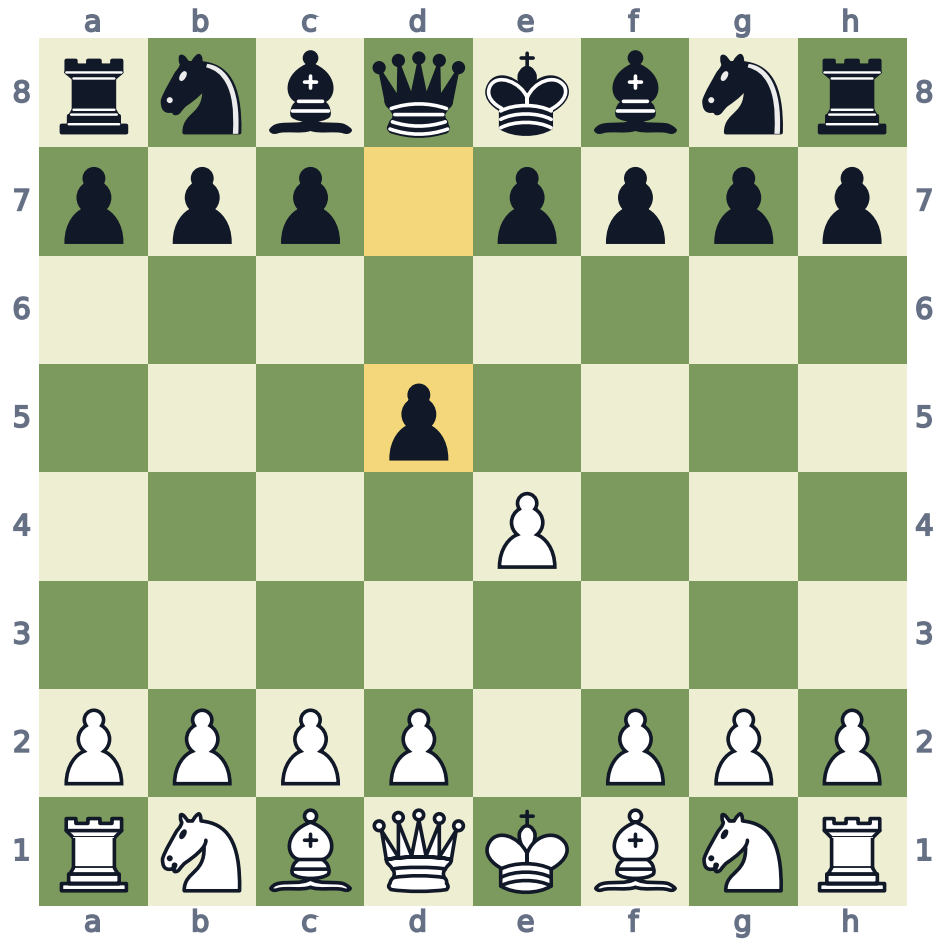
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 02 OF 36

Scandinavian 2...c6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 03 OF 36

Alapin ...d6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

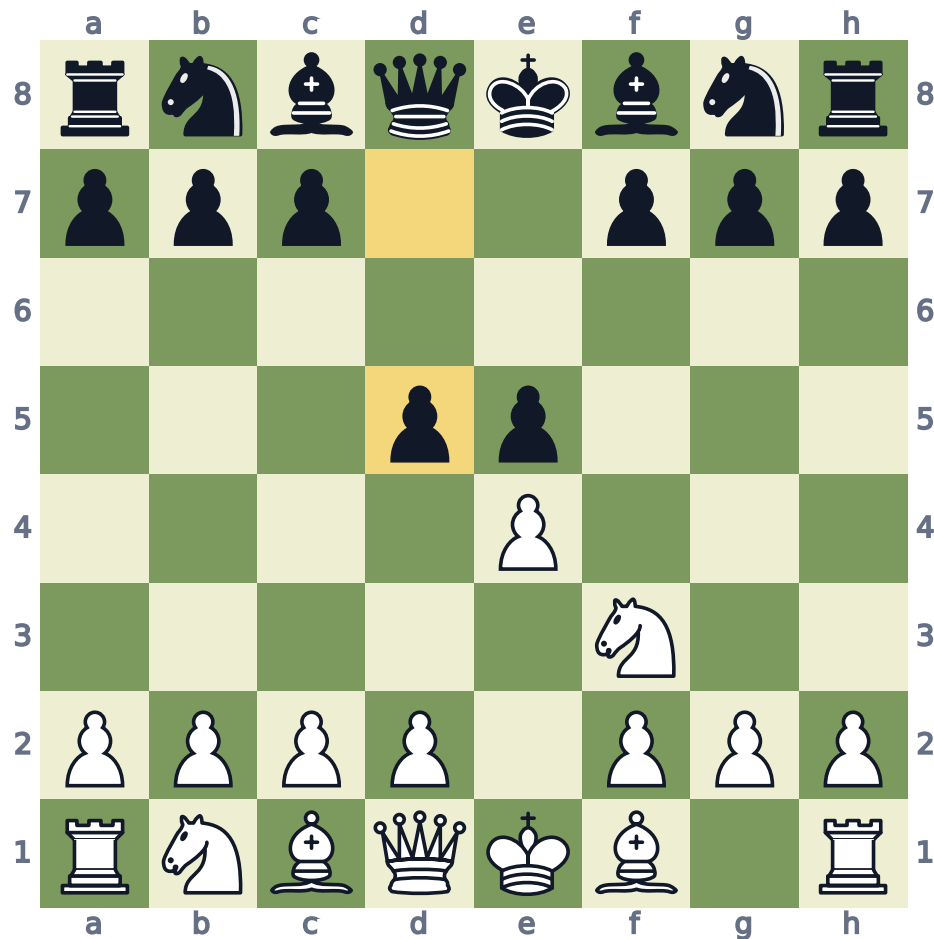
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 04 OF 36

Elephant Gambit

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

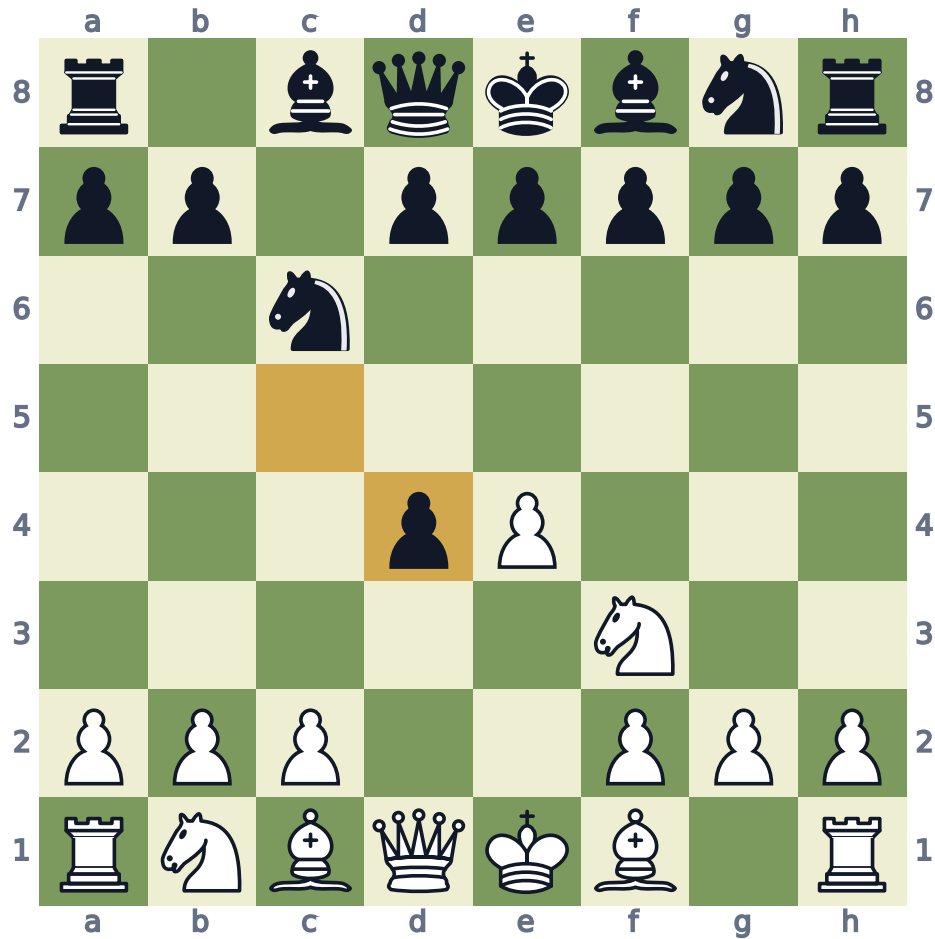
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 05 OF 36

Accelerated Dragon



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

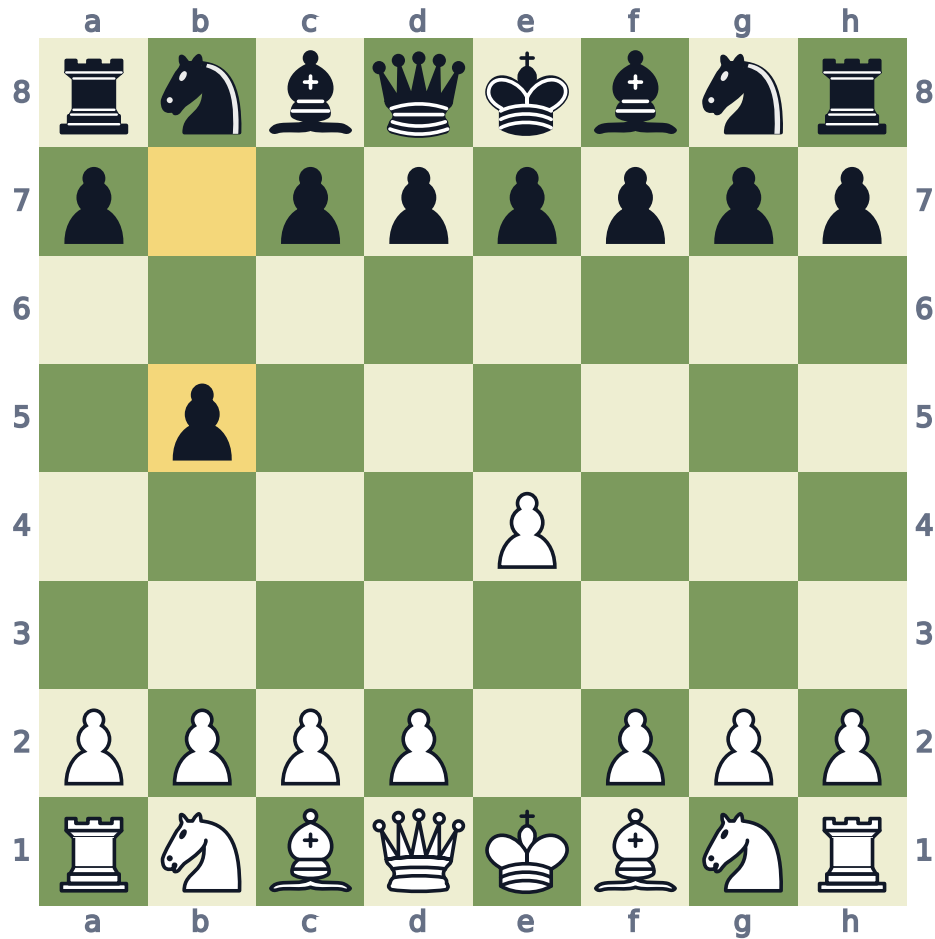
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 06 OF 36

1...b5

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 07 OF 36

Sveshnikov core

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 08 OF 36

Alapin ...b6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

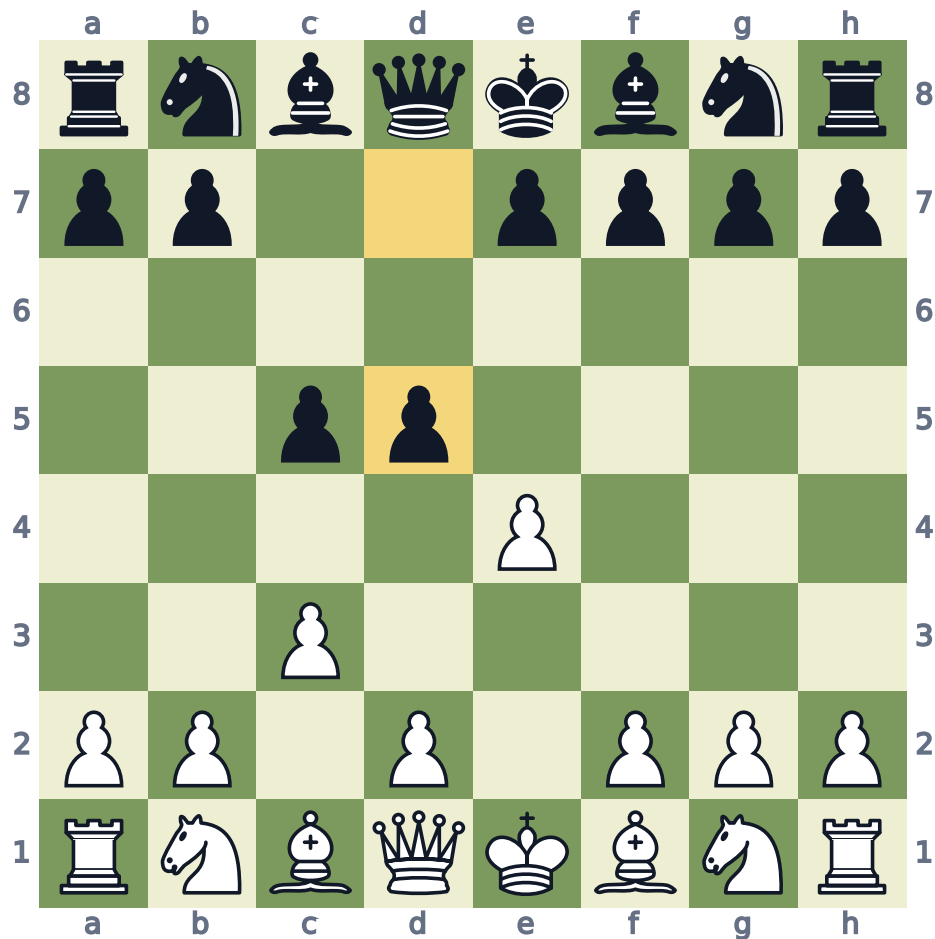
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 09 OF 36

Alapin ...d5

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 10 OF 36

French early ...c5



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

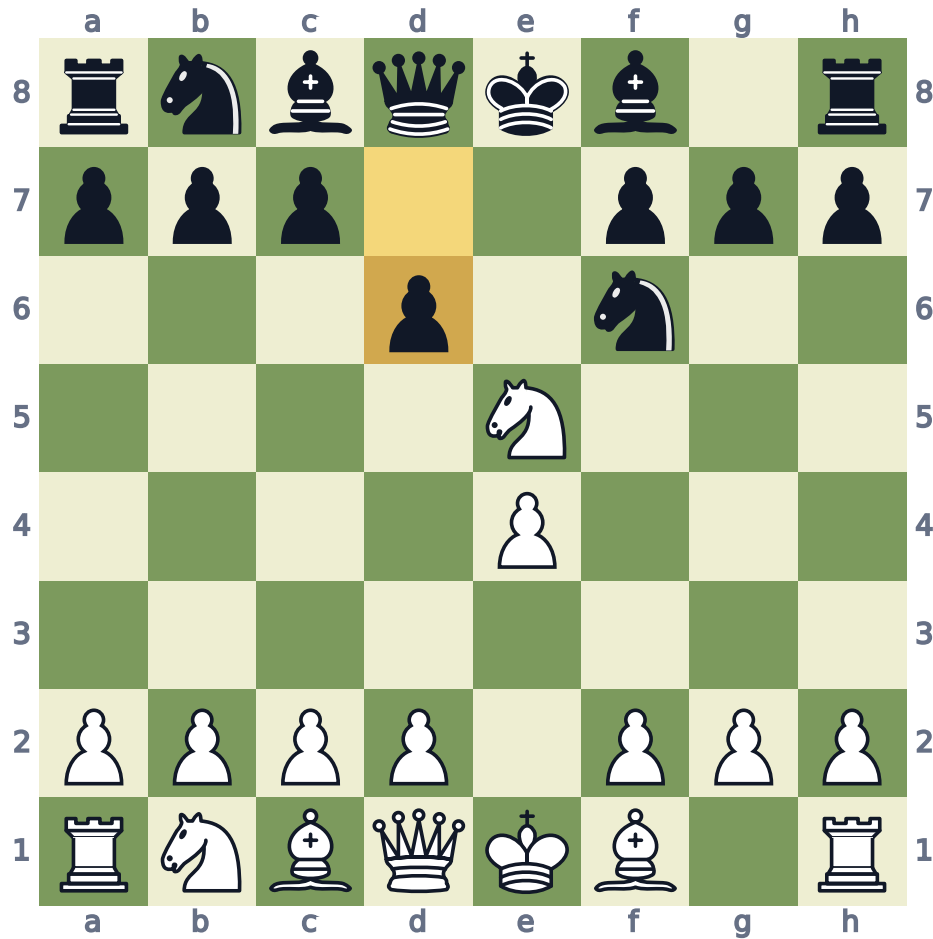
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 11 OF 36

Petroff main line

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

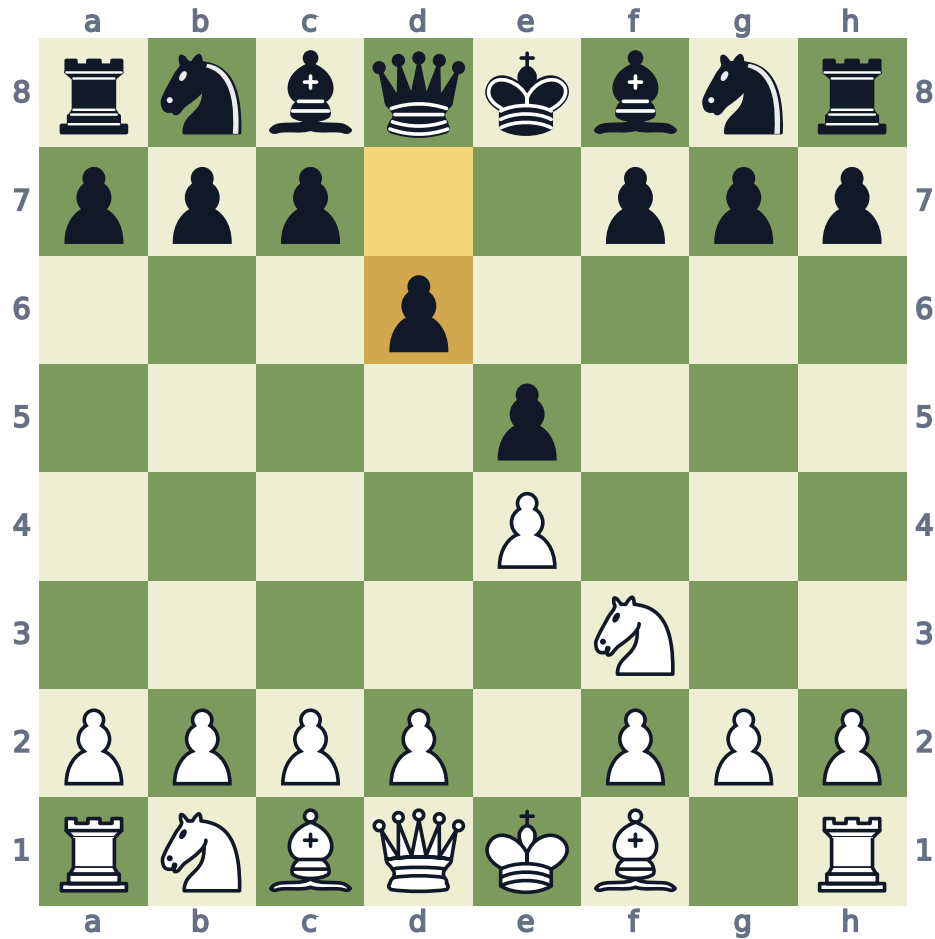
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 12 OF 36

Philidor ...Nf6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 13 OF 36

Nimzowitsch Defense



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

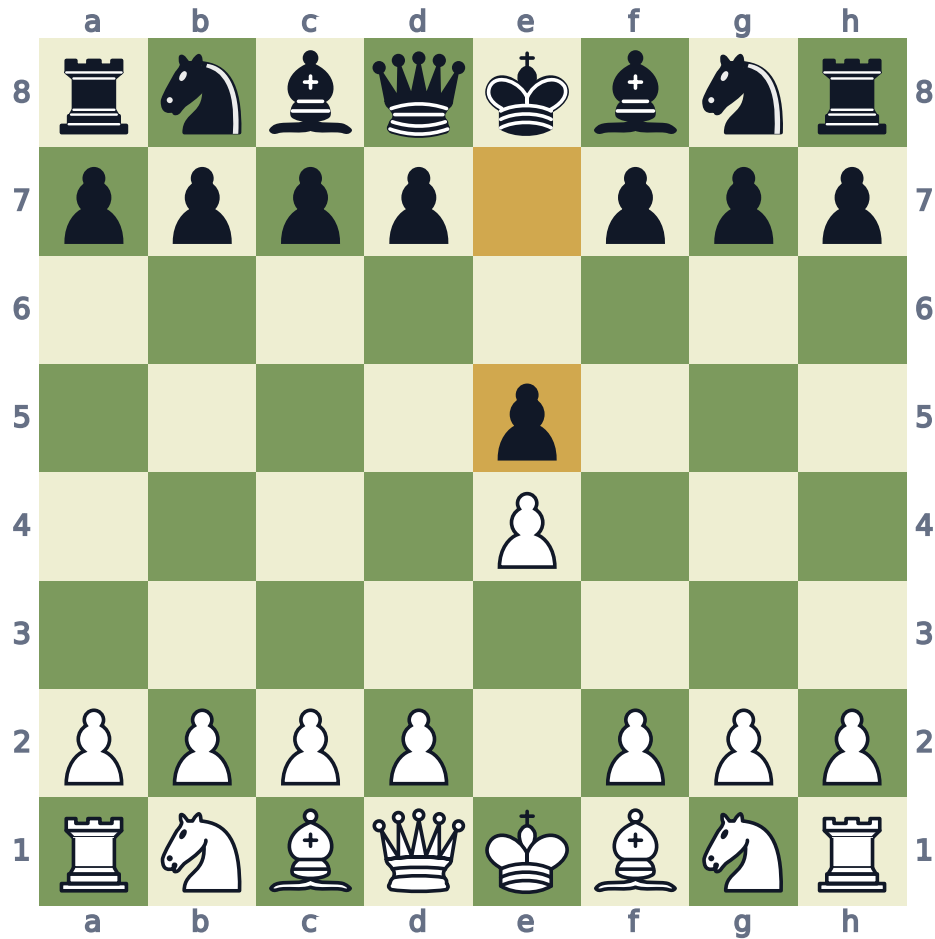
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 14 OF 36

King's Gambit awareness

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

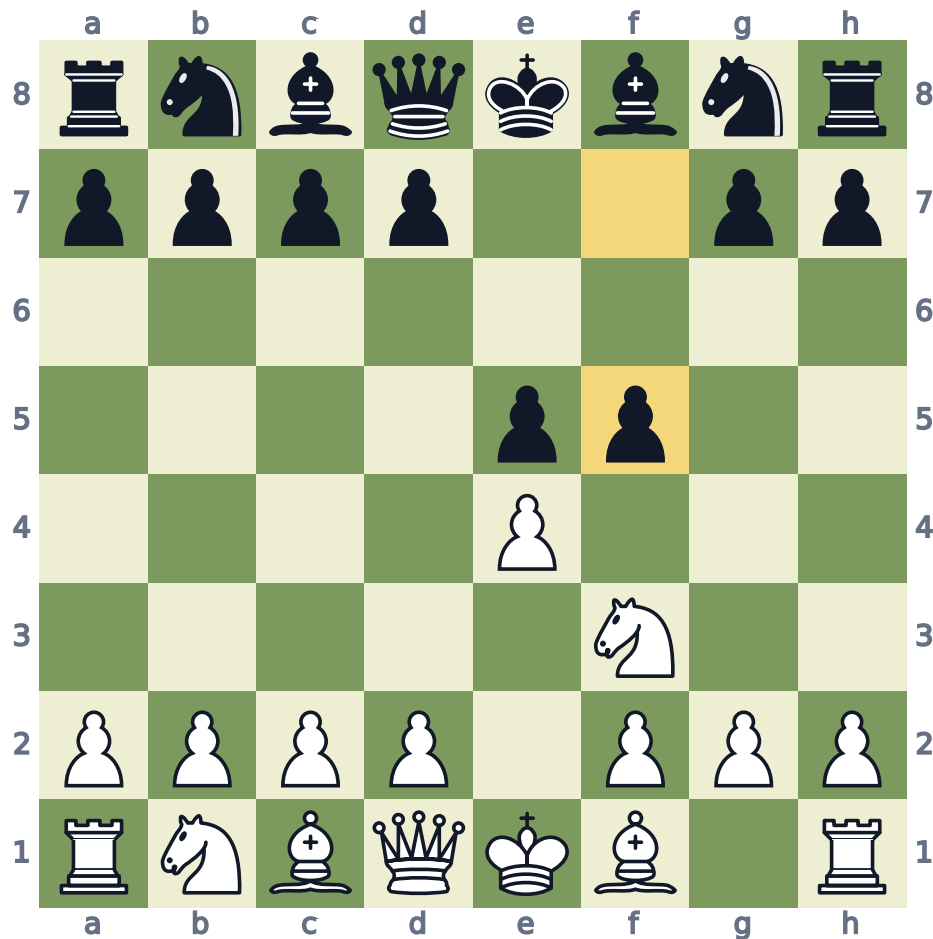
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 15 OF 36

Latvian Gambit



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 16 OF 36

Advance French core

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 17 OF 36

French ...Nh6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 18 OF 36

French ...Bd7

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 19 OF 36

French ...f6 break

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 20 OF 36

Philidor exchange



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

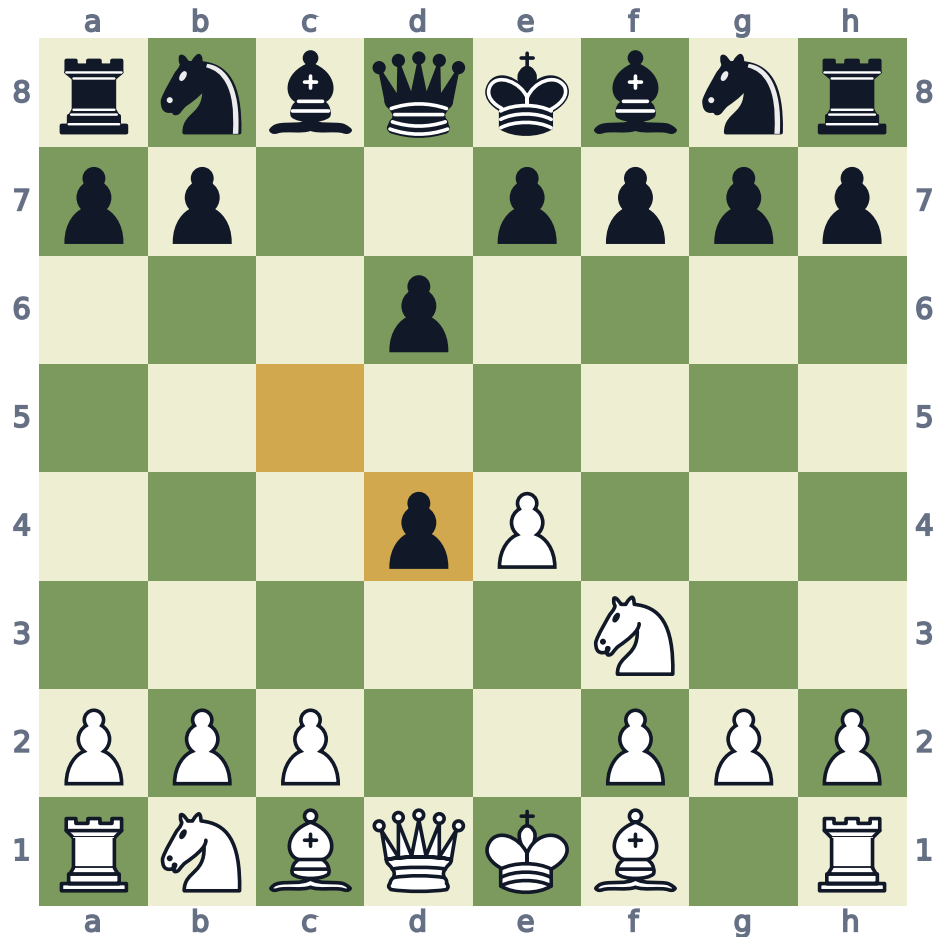
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 21 OF 36

Najdorf English Attack

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

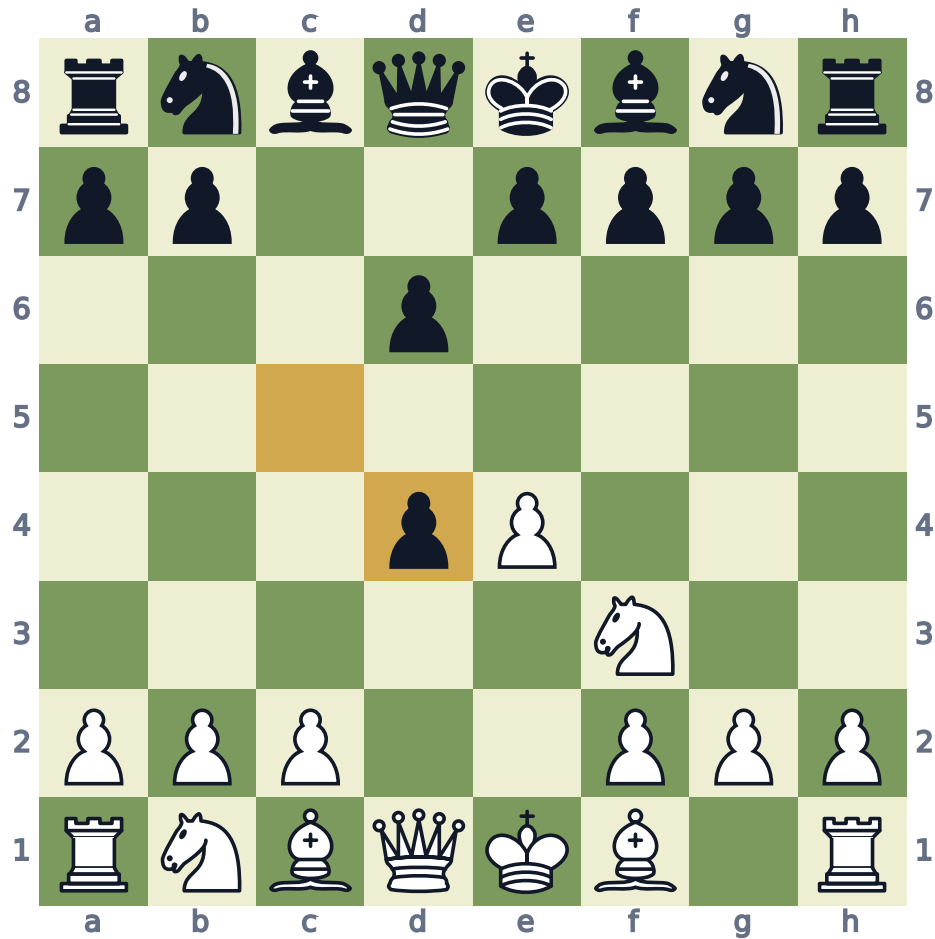
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 22 OF 36

Najdorf ...e5

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

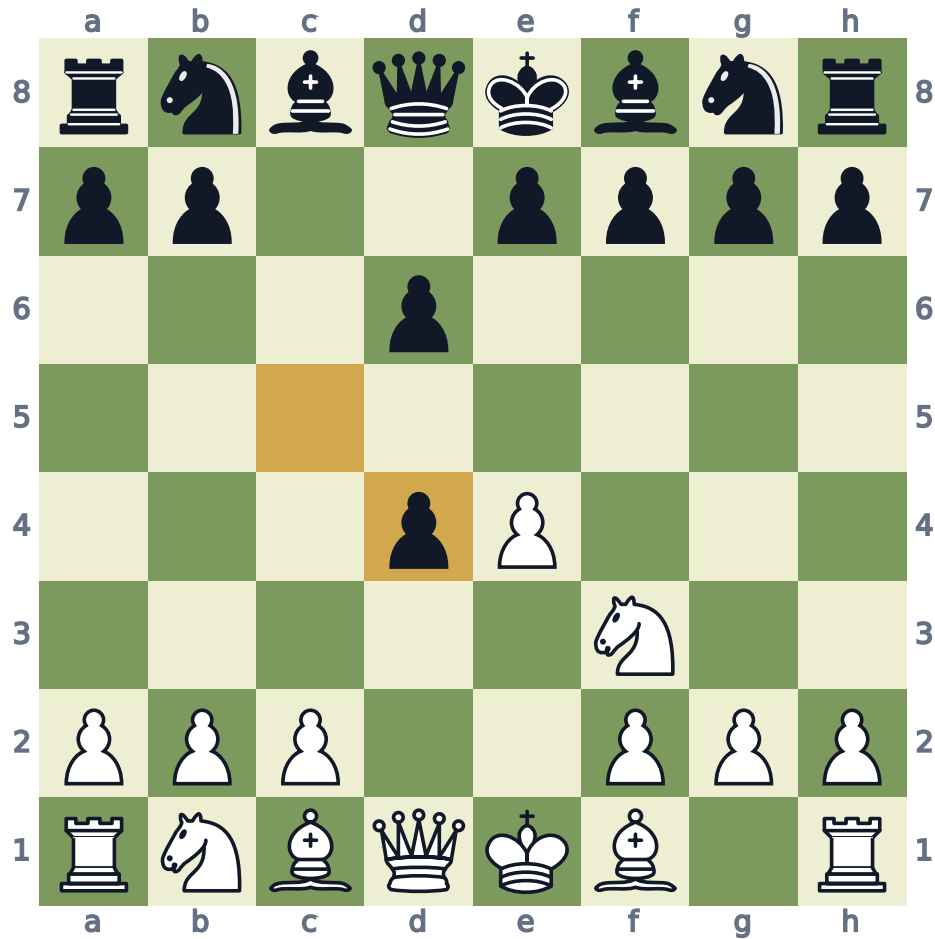
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 23 OF 36

Najdorf ...Ng4

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

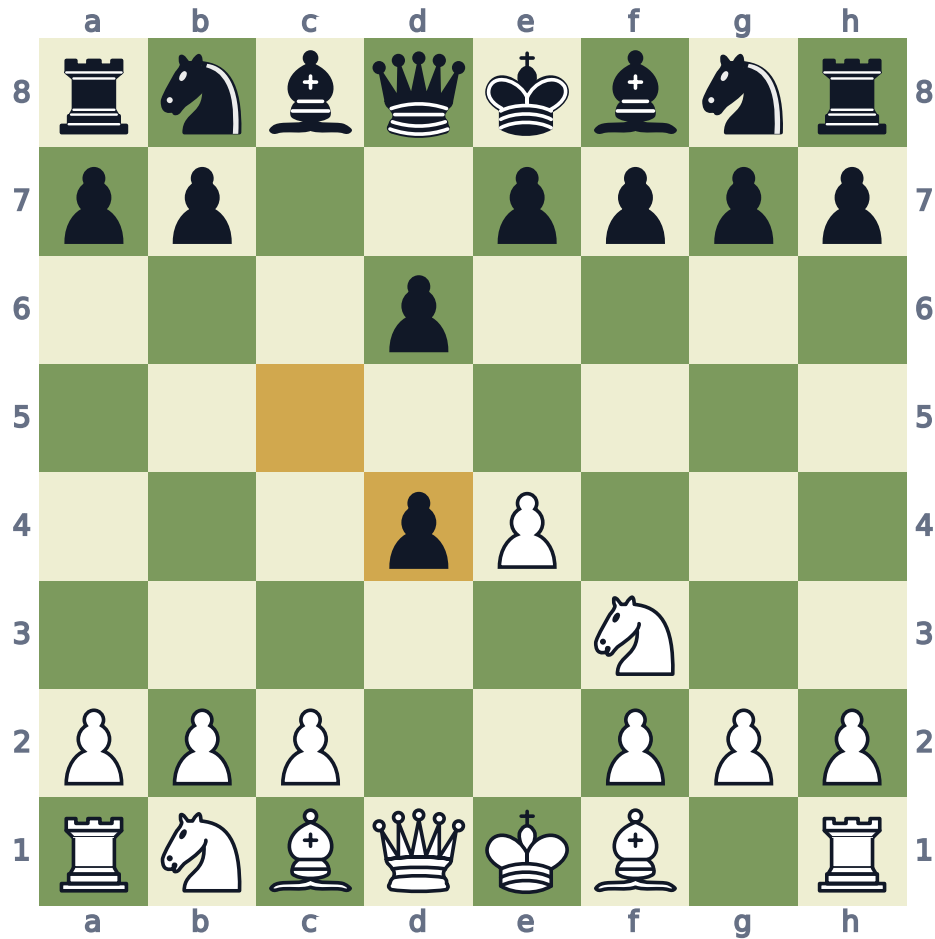
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 24 OF 36

Dragon Yugoslav setup



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

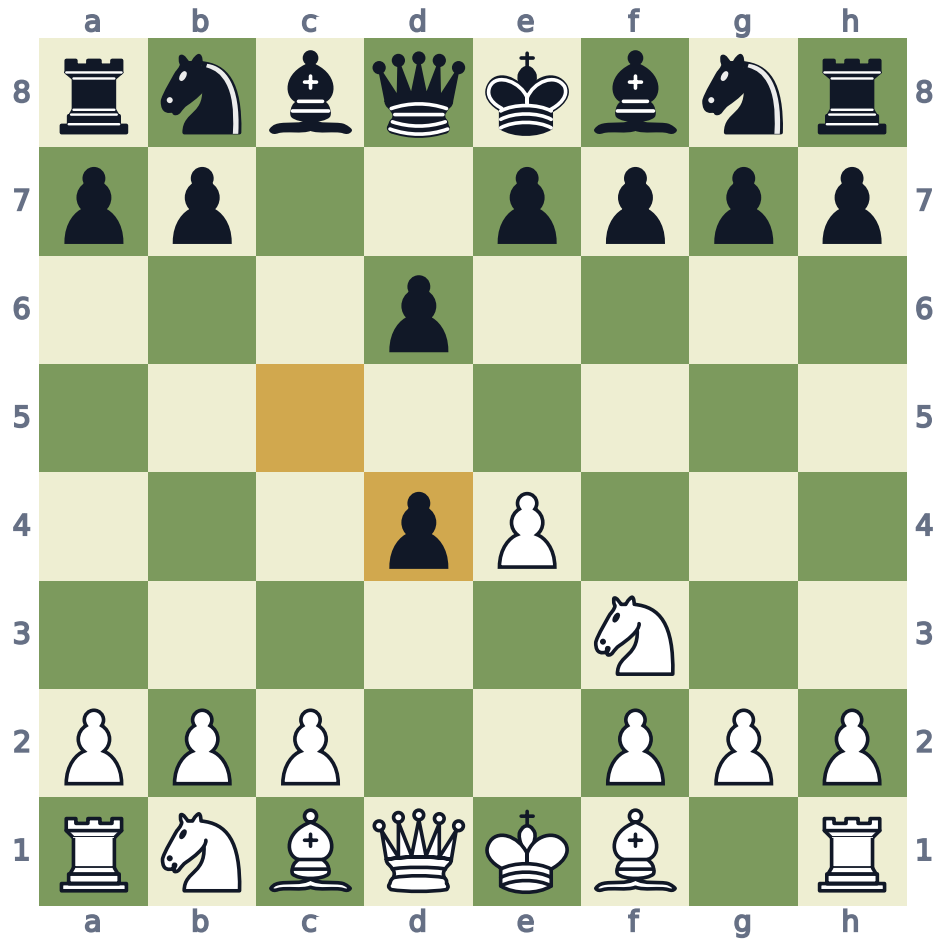
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 25 OF 36

Scheveningen shell



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

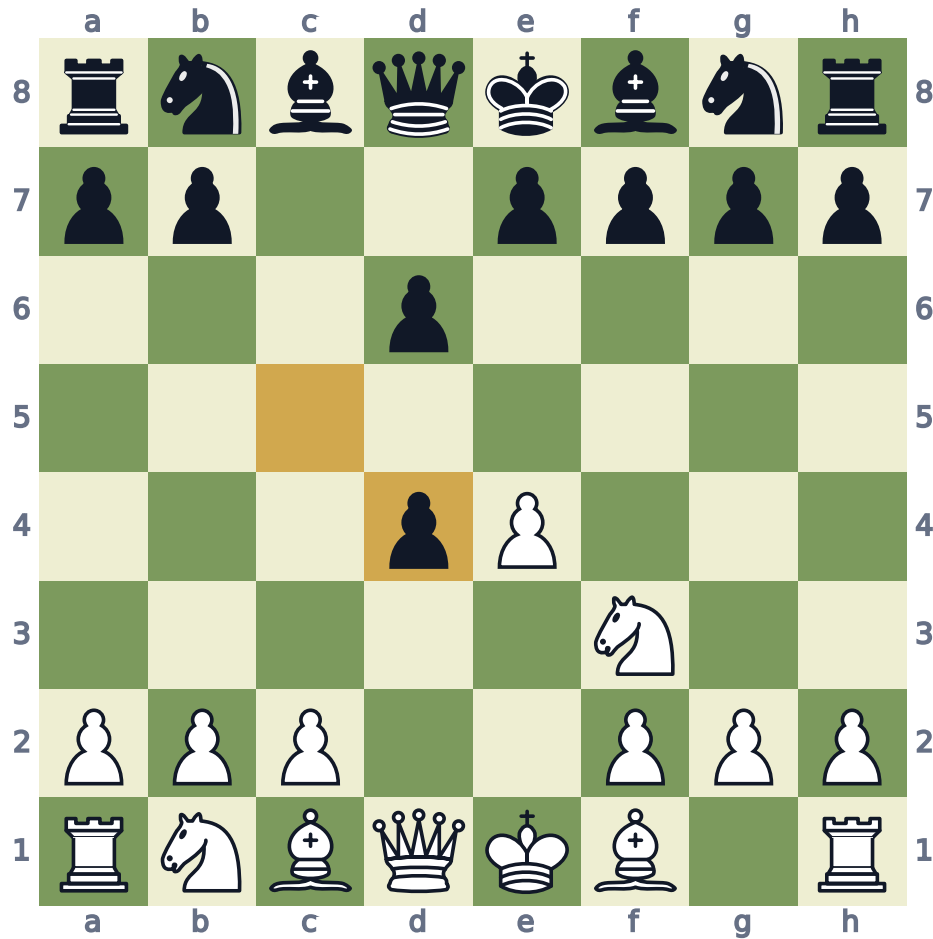
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 26 OF 36

Najdorf Be2 alternative

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

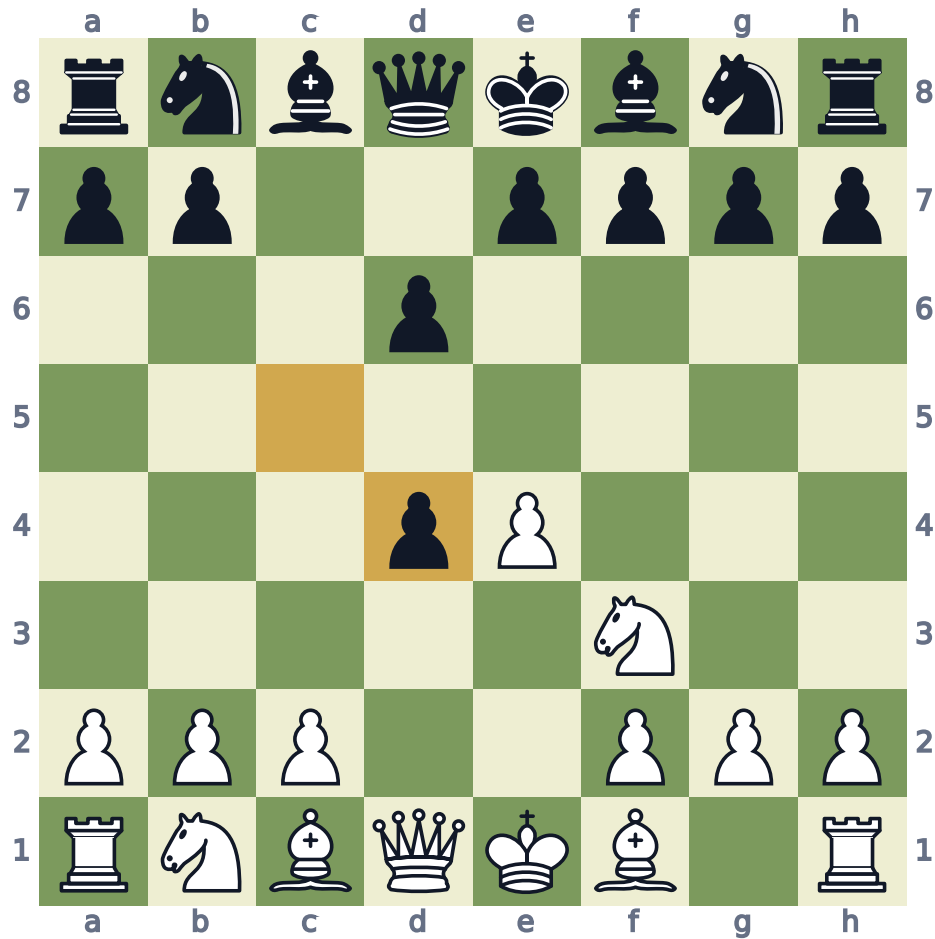
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 27 OF 36

Classical Sicilian



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

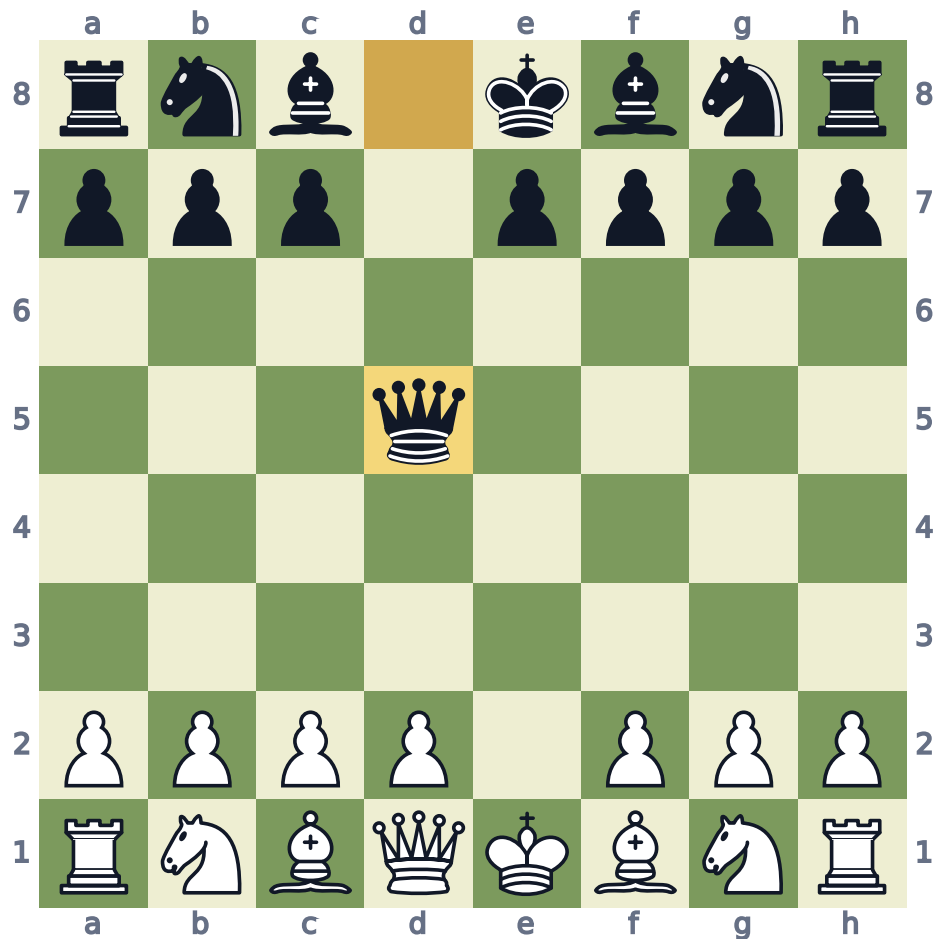
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 28 OF 36

Scandinavian ...Qd8

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

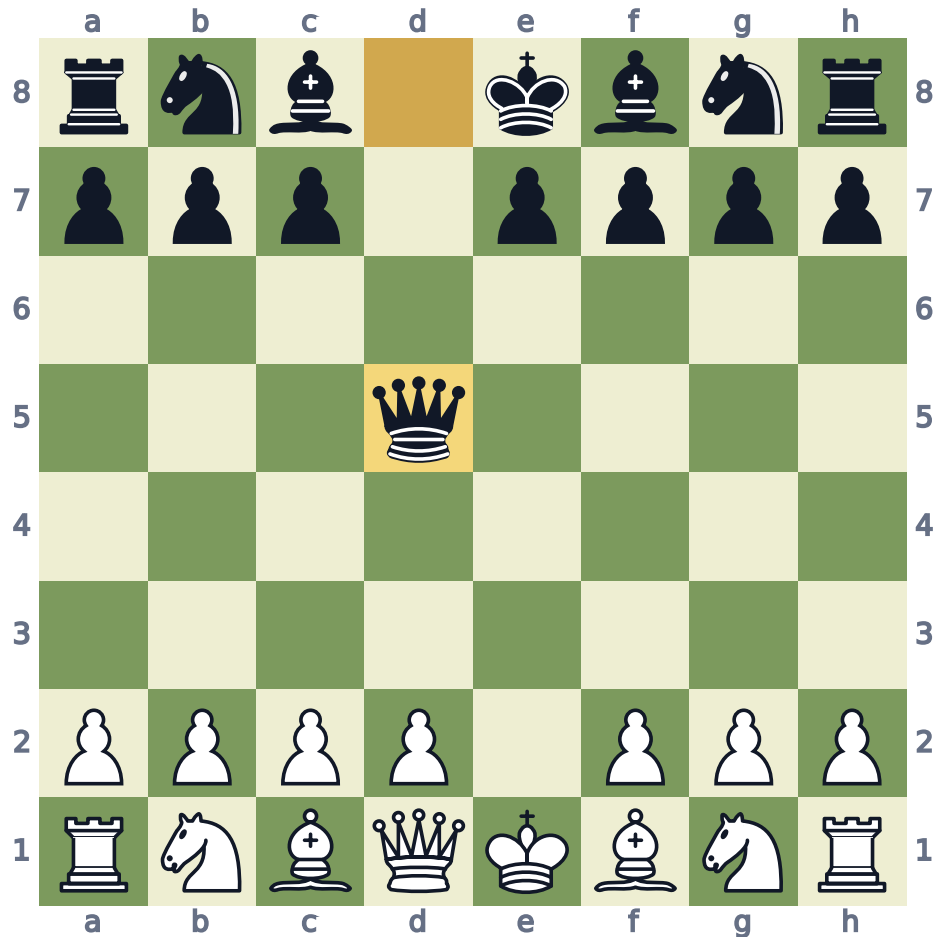
White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 29 OF 36

Scandinavian ...Qa5

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

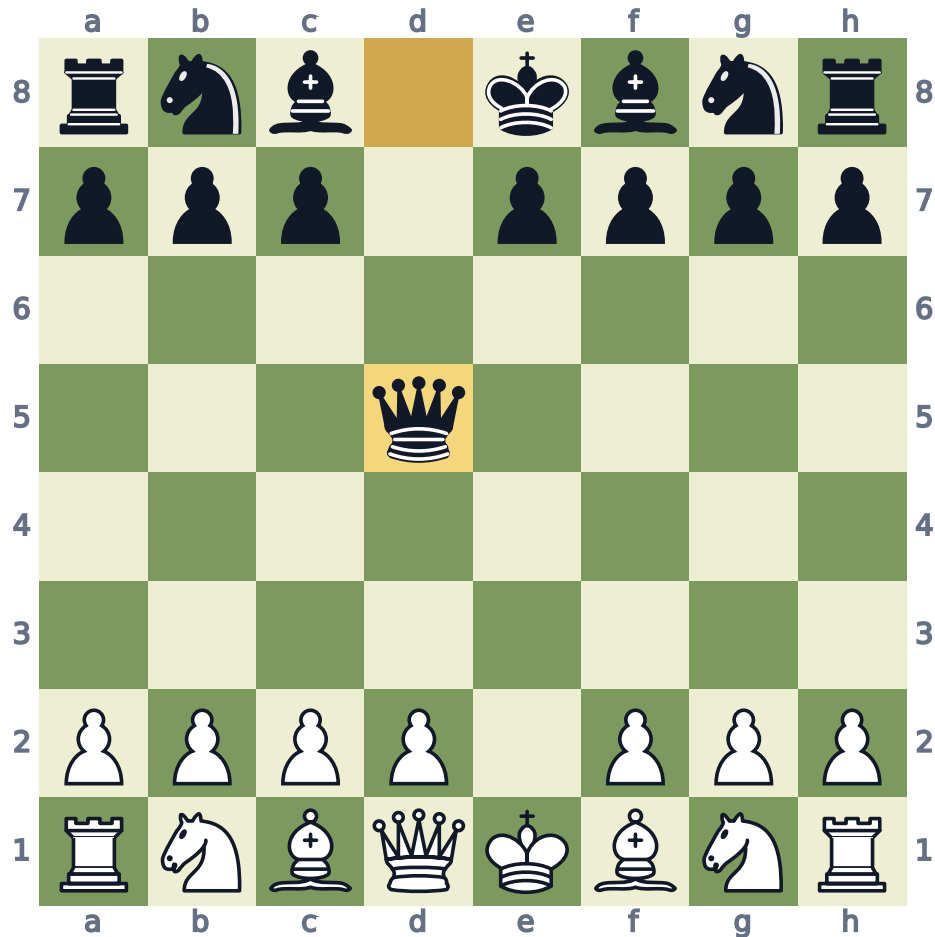
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 30 OF 36

Scandinavian ...Qd6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 31 OF 36

Alapin ...g6

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

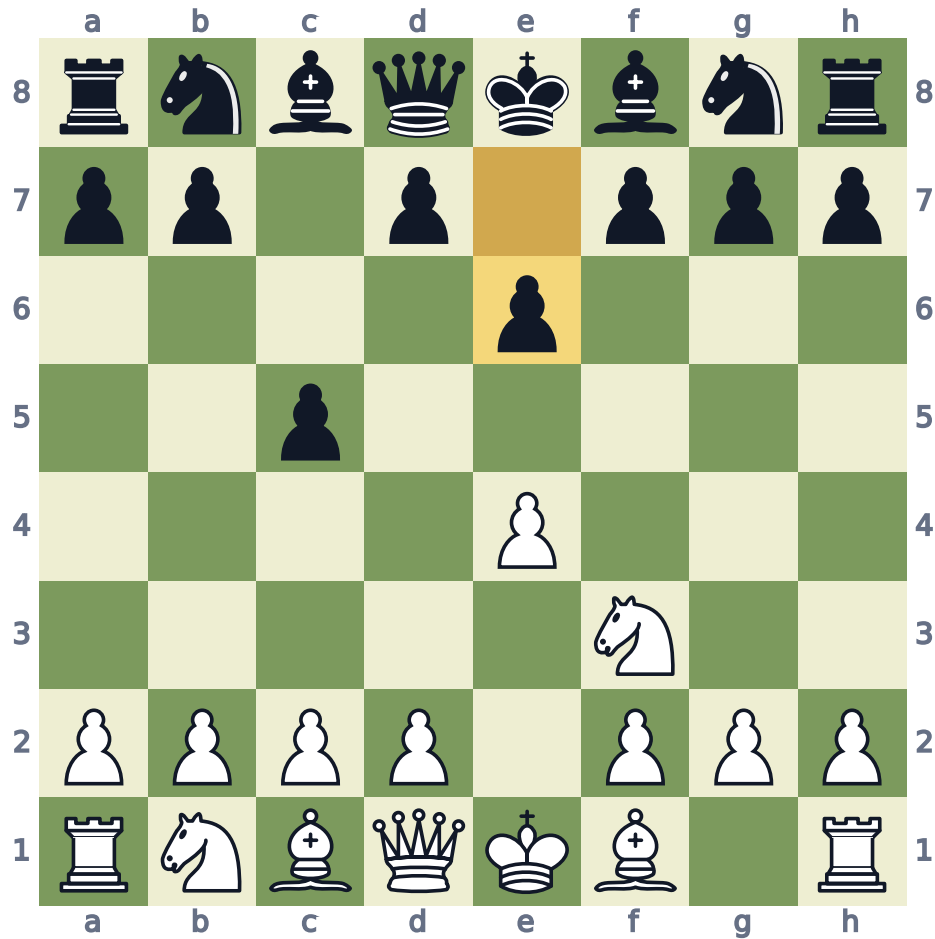
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 32 OF 36

Delayed Alapin



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 33 OF 36

Najdorf Poisoned Pawn awareness



CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 34 OF 36

Dragon with Bc4

**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

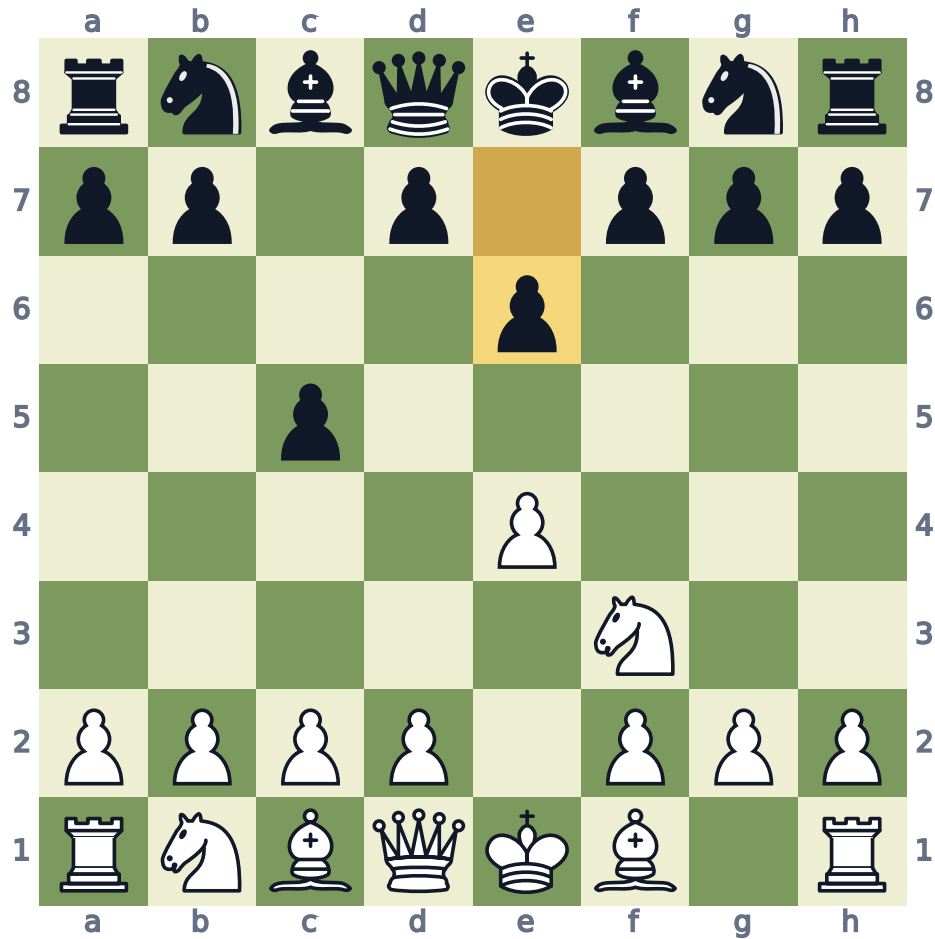
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SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

TACTICAL TEST 35 OF 36

Taimanov

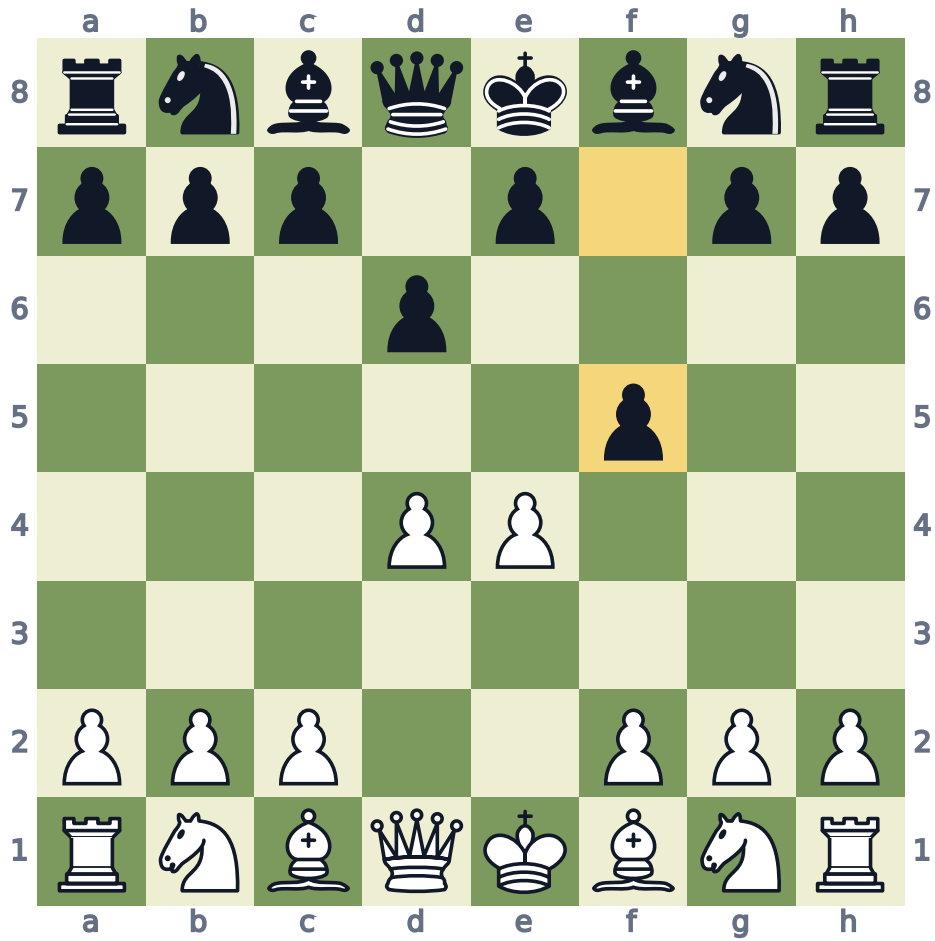
**CALCULATE BEFORE REVEALING THE ANSWER**

White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

SCORING

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

Rat Defense



White to move. First identify the opponent's threat or tactical idea. List checks, captures, and forcing threats. Choose a move, calculate at least three plies, and state whether the solution is tactical, developmental, or a move-order prevention.

2 recognition | 2 candidates | 3 calculation | 2 endpoint | 1 explanation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Tactical solutions begin here

SCORING HONESTY

A correct first move earns at most 2 points if the line or reason was missing. If the engine move differs from the repertoire move, record why: tactics, transposition, or a small positional preference. The goal is accurate thinking, not worship of a number.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 1-3

01. FRED DEFENSE

Engine move: exf5. Line: 1. exf5 Nf6 2. d4 d5 3. Bd3 c5 4. c3 e6 5. fxe6 Bd6. Evaluation: +1.44 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Accept the pawn while developing and controlling the center. Warning: Trying to keep f5 with pawns can expose the king.

02. SCANDINAVIAN 2...C6

Engine move: exd5. Line: 1. exd5 Qxd5 2. Nc3 Qd8 3. Nf3 g6 4. d4. Evaluation: +0.75 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Accept temporarily and return material through development if needed. Warning: Keeping the pawn can expose the queen and delay castling.

03. ALAPIN ...D6

Engine move: d4. Line: 1. d4 Nf6 2. Bd3 g6 3. Nf3 Bg7 4. h3 Qc7 5. O-O a6. Evaluation: +0.72 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Build the center and castle before choosing e5 or Re1. Warning: The e4 pawn can be hit by ...Bg7 and ...O-O.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 4-6

04. ELEPHANT GAMBIT

Engine move: exd5. Line: 1. exd5 e4 2. Qe2 Nf6 3. d3 Qxd5 4. Nbd2 Bb4. Evaluation: +1.07 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Accept the pawn but prioritize development and central control. Warning: The e4 pawn can chase the knight and open lines with tempo.

05. ACCELERATED DRAGON

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 e5 3. Ndb5 d6 4. Bg5 a6 5. Bxf6 gxf6. Evaluation: +0.34 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Control d5 and be ready for the Maroczy Bind with c4. Warning: Black seeks ...d5 in one move and can equalize if it works.

06. 1...B5

Engine move: Bxb5. Line: 1. Bxb5 Bb7 2. Nc3 e6 3. d4 Nf6 4. Qe2 c6 5. Bd3 c5. Evaluation: +1.69 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Take the pawn but develop against the bishop's central pressure. Warning: The b7 bishop can create tactics on e4 and g2.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 7-9

07. SVESHNIKOV CORE

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 e5 2. Ndb5 d6 3. Bg5 a6 4. Bxf6 gxf6 5. Na3 b5. Evaluation: +0.49 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the d5 outpost and pressure the weakened dark squares. Warning: Black gains activity and queenside space with tempo.

08. ALAPIN ...B6

Engine move: d4. Line: 1. d4 e6 2. d5 Nf6 3. Bd3 exd5 4. e5. Evaluation: +1.00 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Protect e4 and build the center against the queenside fianchetto. Warning: The b7 bishop can make e4 tactically vulnerable.

09. ALAPIN ...D5

Engine move: exd5. Line: 1. exd5 Qxd5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 Nf6 4. Be2 cxd4 5. cxd4 Qa5+. Evaluation: +0.25 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Accept central exchanges and gain development against the queen. Warning: Nc3 can invite a queen capture on d4 if the center is loose.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 10-12

10. FRENCH EARLY ...C5

Engine move: d5. Line: 1. d5 exd5 2. exd5 d6 3. Bd3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Nbd7 5. c4 Qe7+. Evaluation: +0.71 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the space and advanced passer while completing development. Warning: The d6 pawn can become blockaded and weak.

11. PETROFF MAIN LINE

Engine move: Nf3. Line: 1. Nf3 Nxe4 2. d4 d5 3. Bd3 Bd6 4. O-O O-O 5. c4 c6. Evaluation: +0.51 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use central space and active development in a symmetrical structure. Warning: The e-file and e4 knight create tactical details.

12. PHILIDOR ...NF6

Engine move: d4. Line: 1. d4 exd4 2. Nxd4 Nf6 3. Nc3 Be7 4. Bf4 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.76 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Develop naturally and keep d5 as a possible space gain. Warning: Black can strike with ...c6 and ...d5 if White drifts.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 13-15

13. NIMZOWITSCH DEFENSE

Engine move: e5. Line: 1. e5 Bf5 2. Nf3 e6 3. c3 a6 4. Be2 f6 5. Nbd2 fxe5. Evaluation: +0.60 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use development with tempo against the early queen. Warning: The queen can take d4 if White's center is loose.

14. KING'S GAMBIT AWARENESS

Engine move: Nf3. Line: 1. Nf3 Nf6 2. Nxe5 Qe7 3. d4 Nc6 4. Nc3. Evaluation: +0.49 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Understand the attacking structure while keeping the Italian as the main repertoire. Warning: The open king and f-pawn loss create long-term risk.

15. LATVIAN GAMBIT

Engine move: Nxe5. Line: 1. Nxe5 Qf6 2. d4 d6 3. Nc4 fxe4 4. Nc3 Qg6 5. f3 Nc6. Evaluation: +1.49 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Take the center pawn, meet the queen attack, and develop with tempo. Warning: The queen and f-pawn create immediate threats against e4.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 16-18

16. ADVANCE FRENCH CORE

Engine move: c3. Line: 1. c3 Nc6 2. Nf3 Nge7 3. Na3 Ng6 4. Bd3 cxd4 5. cxd4 Nh4. Evaluation: +0.33 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Support the center, develop, and prepare kingside play or queenside defense. Warning: d4 is attacked repeatedly and can collapse tactically.

17. FRENCH ...NH6

Engine move: c3. Line: 1. c3 Nc6 2. Nf3 Nge7 3. Na3 Ng6 4. Bd3 cxd4 5. cxd4 Nh4. Evaluation: +0.33 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Develop while Black reroutes the knight toward f5. Warning: Bxh6 can help Black's queen and dark-square attack.

18. FRENCH ...BD7

Engine move: c3. Line: 1. c3 Nc6 2. Nf3 Nge7 3. Na3 Ng6 4. Bd3 cxd4 5. cxd4 Nh4. Evaluation: +0.33 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Castle and keep the center supported before choosing a recapture. Warning: The d4 pawn can become isolated after exchanges.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 19-21

19. FRENCH ...F6 BREAK

Engine move: c3. Line: 1. c3 Nc6 2. Nf3 Nge7 3. Na3 Ng6 4. Bd3 cxd4 5. cxd4 Nh4. Evaluation: +0.33 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Meet the pawn-chain attack with calm development and calculate exf6. Warning: Opening the f-file can expose White's king or e5.

20. PHILIDOR EXCHANGE

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 Be7 3. Bf4 O-O 4. Qd2 Nc6 5. O-O-O Nxd4. Evaluation: +0.70 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the open center and easier development. Warning: A careless f4 can expose e4 and the king.

21. NAJDORF ENGLISH ATTACK

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3 e5 4. Nb3 Be7 5. f3 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.43 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Prepare long castling and a kingside pawn advance while controlling d5. Warning: Black's queenside attack can reach first.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 22-24

22. NAJDORF ...E5

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3 e5 4. Nb3 Be7 5. f3 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.43 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Preserve the knight and use d5 as a long-term outpost. Warning: Black gains space and can attack d5 with pieces.

23. NAJDORF ...NG4

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3 e5 4. Nb3 Be7 5. f3 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.43 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Keep useful pressure while avoiding an unfavorable bishop trade. Warning: The bishop can lose tempi and become trapped.

24. DRAGON YUGOSLAV SETUP

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3 e5 4. Nb3 Be7 5. f3 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.43 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Prepare long castling and h4-h5 while controlling d5. Warning: The c-file and g7 bishop target White's queenside king.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 25-27

25. SCHEVENINGEN SHELL

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3 e5 4. Nb3 Be7 5. f3 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.43 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use space and prepare long castling against Black's compact center. Warning: Black's ...d5 break can equalize immediately if allowed.

26. NAJDORF BE2 ALTERNATIVE

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3 e5 4. Nb3 Be7 5. f3 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.43 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Choose short castling and positional control when a tactical race is unwanted. Warning: A quiet setup still must meet ...Be6 and ...d5.

27. CLASSICAL SICILIAN

Engine move: Nxd4. Line: 1. Nxd4 Nf6 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3 e5 4. Nb3 Be7 5. f3 Nc6. Evaluation: +0.43 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Develop for long castling while watching ...d5 and ...Ng4. Warning: The c3 knight and e4 pawn can be attacked together.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 28-30

28. SCANDINAVIAN ...QD8

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 Qd8 2. Nf3 g6 3. Bc4 Bg7 4. O-O Nf6 5. Ne5 O-O. Evaluation: +0.69 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the development tempo to build a healthy center and castle. Warning: Do not waste the gained tempo on unnecessary pawn moves.

29. SCANDINAVIAN ...QA5

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 Qd8 2. Nf3 g6 3. Bc4 Bg7 4. O-O Nf6 5. Ne5 O-O. Evaluation: +0.69 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Develop while watching the pin on c3 and pressure on d4. Warning: The queen can support ...e5 or ...Bf5 with tactical pressure.

30. SCANDINAVIAN ...QD6

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 Qd8 2. Nf3 g6 3. Bc4 Bg7 4. O-O Nf6 5. Ne5 O-O. Evaluation: +0.69 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Gain space and use natural development against the centralized queen. Warning: The queen may support ...e5 and kingside castling.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 31-33

31. ALAPIN ...G6

Engine move: d4. Line: 1. d4 d5 2. e5 Nc6 3. Bb5 Bg7 4. Nf3 Qb6 5. Bxc6+ Qxc6. Evaluation: +0.63 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use the center but respond accurately when Black challenges it. Warning: The g7 bishop targets d4 immediately after exchanges.

32. DELAYED ALAPIN

Engine move: d4. Line: 1. d4 cxd4 2. Nxd4 Nf6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e5 Qc7 5. exf6 Bxc3+. Evaluation: +0.50 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Transpose when Black's move order makes c3 useful. Warning: The knight on f3 can block the f-pawn but supports e5 and d4.

33. NAJDORF POISONED PAWN AWARENESS

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 a6 2. Be2 e5 3. Nb3 Be7 4. g4. Evaluation: +0.33 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Use development and open lines as compensation for b2. Warning: This line is highly tactical and requires exact calculation.

SOLUTIONS

Tests 34-36

34. DRAGON WITH BC4

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 a6 2. Be2 e5 3. Nb3 Be7 4. g4. Evaluation: +0.33 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Develop with tempo against d5 and support the attacking setup. Warning: Bc4 can be hit by ...Ne5 or ...Na5.

35. TAIMANOV

Engine move: d4. Line: 1. d4 cxd4 2. Nxd4 Nf6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e5 Qc7 5. exf6 Bxc3+. Evaluation: +0.50 for White (White is slightly better). Positional purpose: Develop flexibly and prevent ...Nf6 or ...Bb4 tactics from gaining time. Warning: Black can strike with ...b5 or ...Nf6 depending on White's setup.

36. RAT DEFENSE

Engine move: Nc3. Line: 1. Nc3 Nf6 2. Bd3 fxe4 3. Nxe4 Nxe4 4. Bxe4 g6 5. c3 Nd7. Evaluation: +1.18 for White (White is clearly better). Positional purpose: Open the center while Black's king and e6 square are weakened. Warning: Holding the pawn can fall behind in development.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.